
Their collective contribution: a paralysed Government and a divided nation. If CPI(M), essentially a regional party with an international pretence, makes election inevitable, Prakash Karat, an apparatchik who lives in redundant ideological abstractions, alone should not be the culprit. He can afford to do that for the cause of anti-Americanism. For being an apparatchik who has nothing at stake except the borrowed Book and the borrowed slogan, he has only an argument to win. The election, anyway, has to be won by the “working classes” of Bengal and Kerala. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has played into his hands, with utmost political naivety.

Manmohan may enjoy maximum credibility and middle class acceptability as an administrator. His entire career is built on economic management, on facts and figures. He succeeded as a daring economic reformer who freed the market from the permit raj because there was a wily political mentor who stood by him. Manmohan, the loyal technocrat who never let his political master down, was made possible by Narasimha Rao. On an issue like the deal, he has to carry not just

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